

A Visit After Years

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“Oh today is my friend’s birthday, I should wish her a happy birthday,” said Aditya.

Aditya Opens WhatsApp ..

Searches for Meenal ..

Conversation :

Aditya : Hey Meenal ! Wishing you a very happy birthday :)

Some 20 mins later ..

Meenal : Thank you so much!

It has been a few years since we graduated but you have never forgotten to wish me, glad to have a friend like you .. And sorry for always forgetting your birthday ..

Almost instantly, Aditya comes online

Aditya : haha happy to learn that it made you happy and ah no worries I am used to people forgetting mine :(

How is everything going?

Meenal : Everything is going good.. My elder sister wedding coming up next week, just involved with that, hence I have taken leave from the office for some days.

What about you, where are you these days .. Last I remember you shifted to Bangalore, right? And where were you working .. some fintech company right? How is it going?

Aditya : Yeah I shifted to bangalore to work at that Fintech Company “xyz” but I left that few days back ..

Meenal : Oh! Wait .. I didn’t know that, so are you looking for a new job ?

Aditya : Yeah yeah .. ofc bro I would (Laughing emoji) I did get a new one .. I would probably be joining 3 weeks later ..

Meenal : Oh great ! What do you plan to do until then?

Aditya : I was thinking of going on a bike trip and exploring Kerala .. with a job getting so many leaves becomes difficult so just packing up for it ..

Meenal : Oh that is so good ... Then you must visit our house for the wedding. My family would be happy to host you.

Aditya : Oh thanks for the offer but I mean ...

Meenal : No ifs and buts .. this is my sincere demand (Cunnig emoji)

Aditya : Well then that is the case ..

Meenal : Keep updating me about your journey! See got loads of work.

Aditya : See you! Enjoy your day :)

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2 days later .. early morning

“Got my riding gear, water, food, medical kit, locked the house .. I am good to go” Aditya said.

He put the key in the bike's handle, unlocked it, changed the gear and revved the bike .. perhaps to let the neighbourhood know that he is going on a ride.

He rode for 2 hrs before he took a tea and restroom break once at the border once he entered Kerala.

Then he drove on those beautiful road curves for another 2 or 3 hrs when he finally reached his friend's town and dropped her a voice message to let her know that he had reached there.

“Hey Meenal .. Just reached, the map shows your house about 20 -30 mins from here .. I am coming !”

He enters the street and it is evident from the decorations which is Meenal's house and stops right outside it and honks.

That is when a big round figure comes from inside, “Yeah ! Are you the delivery boy? Where were you stuck .. I called so many times but why didn't you respond. Leave that.. Give the parcel.

“Wait wait brother .. I am not the delivery boy, I am here to visit Meenal” said Aditya in a tone not to poke the big fellow.

“How do you know her, huh?” the big fellow said in his dominating tone.

"I am his college batchmate .. She invited me to her sister's wedding, Sir" Aditya said.

"Wait. Let me confirm .. Meenal, where are you?" the big fellow shouted.

"Yes, Chetta?" came Meenal's voice from inside the house.

"Some gentlemen at the gate, who claim to be your college batchmate. You know him?" replied the big fellow.

"Wait .. coming " saying that she comes out of the house.

"Oh Aditya you have come! Chetta, he is my friend ... Aditya, he is my elder brother, Anand " said Meenal.

Meenal turns to Aditya, gives her a side hug and both shake their hand.

"How was your journey? How was Kerala so far, enjoyed it?" Meenal said.

"Yeah, it was beautiful .. no doubts about that. Bro the house looks pretty" Aditya replied.

"Why wouldn't it, I decorated it" Meenal said being proud of it.

"Oh then it deserves to look pretty." Aditya said cheekily. And added "Won't you invite me inside now?"

"Oh sorry! I forgot about it .. you can park the bike in the backyard ... Come, I'll show you" Meenal said.

Both process into the house .. Meenal introduces Aditya to her family ... Aditya greets everyone.

You must be hungry son! Sit, I'll make you some food, said meenal's mom.

Yeah aunty! I was about to say that, said Aditya.

Oh then you should have said that .. don't shy away from asking anything. I'll will bring you food right away

Scene 3 :

Aditya sat on the swinging jhula, quietly observing the house.

People moved around constantly, busy with wedding preparations. Baskets full of flowers were placed in corners. Some worked in pairs, carefully decorating the walls and pillars,

while others were busy in the kitchen preparing sweets and savory dishes. The faint smell of coconut oil and freshly fried snacks lingered in the air.

Someone brought him water, smiling warmly before rushing off again.

Voices filled the house. Conversations, laughter, instructions being passed around.

But for Aditya, it was all just sound.

He could only read expressions, smiles, and gestures. The language was unfamiliar.

And then a thought struck him.

This must have been how Meenal felt during their first semester.

Back then, almost everyone around her spoke Hindi. Fast, effortless Hindi. And she would sit there, trying to follow along, picking up words slowly, depending on him sometimes to translate.

Aditya smiled to himself as another memory surfaced.

One day in the university library, he had come across a book titled *“Be a Pro Hindi Speaker.”* Amused, he had clicked a picture and sent it to Meenal.

Her reply had come instantly.

“Humko Hindi aata.”

The grammar was completely off, but the confidence was unmatched.

He had simply replied, “Yes, I agree,” giving her full marks for the effort.

Sitting there now, surrounded by voices he couldn’t understand, Aditya finally understood what those first few weeks must have felt like for her.

After a while, he got up and walked toward the front yard, taking out his phone to call his parents.

As he spoke to them, he looked around. The greenery, the open space, the calmness of the place felt very different from the rush of Bangalore.

After ending the call, he turned back toward the house.

Just then, Meenal stepped outside.

“So, how is it being here?” she asked with a smile. “And how was Bangalore?”

Before he could answer, she added, “Come, let’s go for a walk.”

Scene 4 :

“Umm, Kerala has been amazing so far... the greenery, the backwaters, the boats... everything just looks so beautiful,” Aditya said, looking around as they walked.

“Bangalore is also good,” he continued, “but it’s quite fast paced. You have to manage so many things.”

“I’ve heard the traffic there is really bad,” Meenal replied.

“Bad?” Aditya laughed. “It’s unpredictable. I usually keep a buffer of 25–30 minutes and still start early just to reach on time.”

They walked along a narrow road lined with tall coconut trees on both sides. The evening felt calm, almost too calm compared to the rush Aditya was used to.

“So how was your old job?” Meenal asked. “Did you enjoy it? And why did you leave?”

“The company was good,” Aditya said. “I was satisfied with the work too, but after a point I didn’t see much growth. And there were talks about the company changing its direction... so I thought it was a good time to move on.”

“Going well,” Meenal said. “Just that sometimes it gets too hectic. But I guess our university prepared us for that,” she added, laughing.

He paused, then smiled.

“Anyway, enough about jobs, Let’s not talk about work,” Aditya said, waving it off.

“You grew up in a place like this and still chose to study in North India?”

Meenal smiled.

“I didn’t know what I was signing up for. First week I thought everyone was fighting because Hindi sounded aggressive.”

Both of them laughed.

“Why don’t you try a word in Malayalam?” Meenal asked.

Aditya thought for a moment.

“What was that word you taught me... Nandi?”

Meenal laughed.

“At least you remember that.”

They walked a little further in comfortable silence.

After a moment, Meenal turned to him and said with a slight grin,

“Wait till tomorrow morning... then you’ll see the real Kerala.”

Aditya looked at her, curious.

“Now I’m interested.”

She just smiled and kept walking.

Scene 5

Next morning

Aditya woke up and, out of habit, checked his phone.

6:30 AM.

He was surprised. The house was already buzzing with activity. Voices echoed from downstairs, utensils clinked, and people moved around as if the day had already been in full swing for hours.

He turned to the other side, hoping to get another half hour of sleep.

But no matter how much he tried, sleep wouldn’t come back.

After a few minutes of struggling, he finally gave up, got out of bed, and walked downstairs.

The moment he entered the hall, he saw everyone already busy with preparations for the day.

Just then, Meenal’s mother noticed him.

“Woke up, son? Hope you slept well,” she said warmly.

“Glad to see that even in your generation, people wake up early. See Meenal, it’s a task to wake up in the morning...”

Aditya smiled politely.

When did I say I wake up early? he thought. *It’s because of all this noise.*

“Never mind,” she continued. “Go freshen up. Breakfast will be ready soon. I’ll go wake Meenal.”

“Meenal... Meenal...” she called out as she walked away.

Aditya just stood there, amused.

Some time later

“Amma, I’m going to bring the coconuts,” Anand said. “Do we need anything else?”

“No,” she replied, “but come back early. There’s a lot of work to be done. And take Aditya along. He can also see the market.”

Anand turned toward him.

“Bro, want to join me? Going to get coconuts.”

“Yeah, sure. Why not?” Aditya replied.

At the market

The market was already lively. Small shops lined the road, vendors calling out, people bargaining, and the smell of fresh produce filled the air.

They stopped at a coconut stall.

“How are you, chetta?” Anand greeted the shopkeeper.

“Please pack the coconuts. I’ll pay you.”

Then turning to Aditya, he asked,

“Wanna try one?”

“Of course,” Aditya said.

The shopkeeper skillfully cut open a fresh coconut and handed it to him.

Aditya suddenly remembered Meenal’s words from last evening. “*Wait till tomorrow...*”

Aditya took a sip.

“Whoa... this is too good and there’s so much water in this!” he said, surprised.

Still drinking, he asked,

“How much does it cost?”

“25–30, depending on the coconut,” the shopkeeper replied.

Aditya looked at Anand, almost shocked.

“Chetta, in Bangalore they charge almost triple for this. This is crazy.”

Anand laughed.

“Then we’ll make sure you drink coconut water every day while you’re here... and maybe even send some back with you,” he said with a playful smile.

They both laughed.

Soon, the coconuts were packed into large jute bags. Anand lifted them with ease, and the two of them headed back home

Scene 6

By the time Aditya and Anand reached home, the house was even more lively than before.

People moved around carrying plates, someone was arranging dishes on the table, and the smell of freshly prepared food filled the air.

“Ah, you’re back,” Meenal’s mother said. “Go wash your hands, breakfast is ready.”

Aditya sat down along with a few other family members. Plates were served quickly.

“Try this,” Meenal said, placing something on his plate. “And this... and this also.”

“Wait, let me at least finish one thing,” Aditya said, laughing.

“Eat properly,” her mother added. “You have come all the way, don’t be shy.”

As everyone started eating, conversations began in Malayalam across the table.

Voices overlapped, people spoke quickly, someone said something loudly, and suddenly the whole table burst into laughter.

Aditya looked around, smiled, and gave a small laugh as well.

Meenal noticed.

“You know what they just said?” she asked.

Aditya shook his head.

“No idea.”

She laughed.

“They were talking about how you looked completely confused at the coconut shop,” Meenal said.

Aditya laughed,

“That is true, I was so surprised by the quantity and the price.”

A few minutes later, one of the relatives turned toward Aditya and said something in Malayalam.

Aditya froze for a second, then smiled politely.

“Sorry... I don’t understand Malayalam,” he said.

“Oh!” the relative laughed, slightly embarrassed.

Meenal jumped in, teasing him,
“He knows a few words.”

Aditya looked at her.
“Wait, I do?”

“Yeah, go on,” she said.

Aditya thought for a moment and then said confidently,

“Nandi.”

There was a pause for a second, and then the entire table burst into laughter.

“At least you remember that,” Meenal said, shaking her head.

Encouraged, Aditya added another word he vaguely remembered.

“Vellam?”

Now the laughter was even louder.

“Good, good,” Anand said. “You’ll survive here.”

Aditya laughed along, slightly embarrassed but enjoying the moment.

For the first time since arriving, he didn’t feel like an outsider in the middle of an unfamiliar language.

Scene 7

As the days passed, the house slowly transformed, ready to host the wedding.

Decorations filled every corner. Strings of lights glowed warmly in the evening, flowers lined the walls and pillars, and the house was constantly filled with relatives talking, laughing, and moving around.

Aditya stood quietly, observing it all.

For a moment, he felt something familiar.

Years ago, he used to capture moments like these. People, emotions, small details, everything that others often missed. He would spend hours editing those photos, just to see a smile on someone’s face.

And yet, he rarely appeared in any of them.

His smile was always behind the camera.

His gallery was filled with memories. College friends, random outings, and of course sunsets. Endless sunsets. Something he had probably captured more than anything else.

He smiled to himself.

Worth capturing, he thought.

Without overthinking, he walked to his bag and took out his camera.

He had brought it along for the bike trip, thinking he would capture landscapes along the way. But somehow, he never stopped to take those shots.

Maybe he was meant to use it here.

He turned it on and stepped back into the house.

This time, not as a guest.

But as an observer.

He began with the small things.

Flowers being arranged. Lights being fixed. Someone adjusting decorations again and again.

Then people.

A group laughing loudly over some joke. Kids running around despite being told not to. Mothers scolding them, fathers sitting in a circle, deep in discussion.

Every now and then, someone would walk right in front of the camera, forcing him to pause and adjust.

For the first time in a long while, it didn't feel like effort.

It felt natural.

"Are you the photographer?" someone asked casually while passing by.

Aditya smiled.

"No, just helping around."

But the question stayed with him.

Back in college, people used to call him *the photographer*.

He hadn't heard that in a long time.

Later that evening, after the house had quieted down a bit, Aditya headed to the terrace, sat alone and scrolled through the pictures.

One by one.

Each photo felt like a small story.

And for the first time in years, he felt the same quiet satisfaction he used to feel back then.

Maybe he hadn't lost it after all.

He paused at one picture in particular.

Meenal, laughing, unaware that she was being photographed.

He smiled.

Some things hadn't changed.

Scene 8

As Aditya sat on the terrace wall, looking out at the quiet night, he heard footsteps behind him.

Before he could turn, Meenal suddenly bumped into him.

"Hey!" Aditya said, losing his balance for a second but managing to steady himself.

"Careful," he added, laughing.

"Relax," Meenal said, sitting beside him. "You won't fall that easily."

For a moment, both of them just sat there, enjoying the calm after a long day.

"So," Meenal said, breaking the silence, "what have you decided to gift for the wedding?"

Aditya smiled.

"I'm actually really bad at these things. I'll probably have to call my mom and ask her."

He paused for a second and added,

"But... I do have a surprise planned. You'll see tomorrow. Before I leave."

Meenal looked at him curiously but didn't push further.

After a brief silence, she spoke again, her tone softer this time.

"It feels good... seeing everyone here. All the relatives, the kids... but akka will leave tomorrow."

She paused.

"I'm going to miss her. She takes care of everything in the house."

Aditya nodded.

"That's true... the house will definitely feel different."

Then, with a slight smile, he added,

"But when you leave someday, I think uncle and aunty will finally feel relaxed. The naughty one will be someone else's responsibility."

Meenal immediately pushed his shoulder.

"Shut up!" she said, laughing.

"I'm not going to let the calm stay anywhere."

Both of them laughed.

After a moment, she looked at him and said,

"Thanks for coming, Aditya. It really means a lot. It's been so long since I met any college friends. I don't even know where everyone is now."

Aditya nodded.

"Yeah, same. And how could I say no to my student who worked so hard to learn Hindi, brought me authentic banana chips, and still made time to say hi every time we crossed paths?"

Meenal laughed.

"Those were such good days. I remember how safe I felt... knowing there was someone who could translate for me."

"And that group..." she continued, smiling,
"it took us forever to actually work properly as a team."

Aditya laughed.

"That group was something else."

He paused and added teasingly,

"And you... during winters. Always hiding in your room."

Meenal groaned.

"Winters there were too much. I was not built for that."

"And your reaction to dahi bhalla the first time," Aditya added.

"Okay stop," she said, laughing. "That was new for me."

They both smiled, lost in the memory for a moment.

“Funny, right?” Aditya said.

“At that time we used to complain so much. Assignments, tests, presentations...”

“And now,” Meenal added,

“we miss it.”

Aditya nodded.

“Yeah. You only realize the value of those moments once they’re far behind.”

There was a comfortable silence.

After a while, Aditya stretched slightly.

“I think we should sleep. Big day tomorrow.”

“Yeah,” Meenal said. “I’m exhausted.”

She suddenly remembered something.

“Hey, what’s up with your camera? Show me.”

Aditya shook his head.

“Battery’s dead. I’ll put it on charge now. You can see tomorrow.”

“Alright,” she said.

Both of them got up and headed downstairs.

Scene 9

The final day had arrived.

The house was awake before sunrise.

Voices echoed through the halls, footsteps moved quickly from one room to another, and preparations were already in full swing. As was tradition, the wedding was to take place in the morning, and everyone had something to take care of.

Aditya joined in wherever he could, helping with small tasks, carrying things around, doing what was needed.

Soon, the house shifted from preparation to transformation.

Everyone got ready.

Traditional outfits, jewelry, flowers, and a quiet excitement filled the air.

Aditya got ready too.

And then, as the groom's side arrived, the house came alive.

Welcomes, smiles, greetings, laughter.

Aditya stepped slightly back, camera in hand.

He moved quietly through the crowd, capturing moments as they unfolded.

Two families meeting.

Hands joining.

Smiles that didn't need words.

The rituals began.

The priest called everyone to gather. Families sat close together. Parents beside their children, elders seated just behind, and younger ones watching everything with curiosity and excitement.

Aditya moved around, careful, observant.

Click after click.

Moments he knew would matter later.

Time passed almost unnoticed.

And finally, the rituals came to an end.

The sacred thread was tied.

Applause filled the space.

Flowers and petals were showered as everyone celebrated the union.

The energy slowly shifted toward celebration and food.

As people moved toward lunch, Aditya quietly stepped away and went upstairs.

He sat down, opened his laptop, and began going through the photos.

One by one.

He selected, adjusted, edited.

Then slowly, he began putting them together.

A story.

Some time later, his phone rang.

"Hey bro, where are you?" Meenal's voice came.

"Did you have lunch?"

"Not yet," Aditya replied. "I'll be there in a bit... just finishing something."

"Okay, come soon," she said.

A little while later, Aditya came downstairs.

"Can everyone gather for a minute?" he said.

People slowly turned, curious.

He connected his laptop to the TV screen.

"Just something small," he added.

The video began.

Photos flowed one after another.

Preparations. Decorations. Laughter. Small unnoticed moments. People getting ready. Kids running around. Conversations. Smiles.

And then the wedding.

The rituals. The emotions. The final moment.

The room fell silent.

Everyone watched.

Some smiled. Some laughed softly. Some pointed at themselves on the screen.

When the video ended, there was a pause.

And then, applause.

"That was beautiful," someone said.

"When did you even take all these?" another added.

"You didn't even realize you were around," Anand laughed. "Very quiet photographer."

Aditya just smiled.

Meenal looked at him, clearly the happiest among everyone.

"This is Aditya," she said to her family.

"He used to be part of the photography club in college. He's always loved capturing moments."

She paused and smiled at him.

"He stopped for a while... but I'm glad he's back."

"Thank you," she added softly. "This was a beautiful surprise."

Scene 10

As the day slowly came to an end and people began to leave, Aditya walked up to Meenal and her parents.

"I think I should leave now," he said.

"I still want to explore the rest of Kerala. Thank you so much for everything. I hope I didn't trouble you."

Meenal's parents immediately responded,

"Why are you leaving today? You must be tired. Stay tonight, rest properly, and leave tomorrow."

Aditya smiled.

"That actually sounds better," he said.

Next morning

Aditya came downstairs with his bag packed.

The house was much calmer now.

He turned to Meenal.

"So... one last question," he said.

"I'm guessing you haven't explored all of Kerala properly either. Want to join me for a short ride? I'll drop you back."

Meenal laughed.

"No chance. I'm still recovering from yesterday. I think I'll just sleep."

Aditya smiled.

"Fair enough. That sounds like a better plan."

They both laughed.

There was a brief pause.

"Come again," she said.

"Next time, don't wait for a wedding."

Aditya nodded.

"Next time, I won't."

He picked up his bag, walked toward his bike, and started it.

As he rode away, the road ahead looked long and open.

But this time, he knew—

Some places weren't just destinations.

They stayed with you.